

Social Media Policy

St Albans United Reformed Church

This policy emphasizes safety, respect, honesty, accountability, and responsible representation of the church online.

Core Principles

We encourage social media use that reflects the values and mission of the church, aiming to communicate the Gospel, share church life, and foster relationships locally and globally. Key principles include:

- **Be Safe:** Protect children, young people, and adults at risk. Follow the URC's online safety policy and consult safeguarding officers if concerns arise.
- **Be Respectful:** Avoid discriminatory, defamatory, or harassing comments. Maintain a tone consistent with Christian values.
- **Be Kind:** Treat others as we would wish to be treated, considering tone and intent when posting or responding to criticism.
- **Be Honest:** Ensure credibility and fairness in all posts.
- **Take Responsibility:** Be accountable for our online actions. If unsure, refrain from posting.
- **Be a Good Ambassador:** Recognize that personal and professional life can blur online; we represent the URC and Christ.
- **Think Before Posting:** Consider the impact of our content on the church, wider community, and public perception.

Publishing Guidelines

This policy stresses that once content is published online, it enters the public domain and may be widely shared, often before retraction is possible. To maintain professionalism and protect the church's reputation:

- Avoid publishing personal information that identifies individuals.
- Ensure content is factual, proof-read, and free of errors before posting.
- Consider whether the content serves the public interest, portrays the church positively, and aligns with Christian values.
- Press releases and official statements should be approved and carefully checked before dissemination.

Practical Application

The URC provides guidance for national accounts, Synod channels, and local congregations, covering platforms like Facebook, X (Twitter), Instagram, WhatsApp, blogs, and websites. Churches are encouraged to:

- Use social media to engage communities and share news responsibly.

- Follow visual identity and branding guidelines to maintain consistency.
- Apply crisis communication strategies when necessary to manage sensitive situations.

By adhering to these policies, URC members and staff can use social media effectively while safeguarding the church's integrity and promoting positive engagement online.